

Session 7: Let Them Go!

Key Takeaways

- The purpose of the release of the Israelites is for them to worship Yahweh.
- The purpose of the confrontation is that the nations will know Yahweh.

Signs

God gives Moses four signs that demonstrate Moses is God's chosen representative.

- Return to the mountain ([Exod. 3:12](#))
- Staff into snake ([Exod. 4:2-5](#))
- Diseased hand ([Exod. 4:6-8](#))
- Water to blood ([Exod. 4:9](#))

Pharaoh was often depicted with a shepherd's staff and a snake headdress, representing a goddess of lower Egypt. Snakes were associated with royal authority.

Moses' staff would confirm his authority to Pharaoh and initiate five plagues, part the Sea of Reeds, bring water from a rock, and decide the battle against Amalek.



Andreas F. Voegelin, Antikenmuseum Basel, and Sammlung Ludwig (2010). Golden Coffin. [NBC News](#).

King Tutankhamun with rod/staff and flail/whip and snake headdress.

With a Mighty Hand and an Outstretched Arm

The phrase “with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm” appears throughout the Hebrew Bible in reference to God’s show of power in delivering the Israelites from slavery in Egypt.

- Mighty hand: [Exodus 6:1](#); [13:3](#), [9](#), [14](#), [16](#); [14:31](#)
- Outstretched arm: [Exodus 6:6](#); [Deuteronomy 4:34](#); [5:15](#); [7:19](#); [9:29](#); [11:2](#); [26:8](#); [Jeremiah 32:21](#)

Deuteronomy 26:8 NIV

So the LORD brought us out of Egypt with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm, with great terror and with signs and wonders.

The use of this phrase challenges the common depiction of the Pharaoh as the one with a “mighty hand and outstretched arm.”



Anonymous. Palette of Narmer (31-30 B.C.E.). [Wikimedia](#).

Narmer Palette, detail (2 ft. tall). Pharaoh Narmer, followed by his sandal bearer, is smiting the head of a foe. The “mace-pose” was standard for over 3,000 years in Egypt. See the Khan Academy article on the Narmer Palette for more information.

Purpose of Release

The expressed purpose for the release of the Israelites is that they might worship and serve God.

Exodus 5:1 Instructor's Translation

YHWH, the God of Israel, says this: “Send away my people, **that they may celebrate a festival in my honor in the wilderness.**”

This is the first prophetic announcement in the Bible, following the standard format, “Thus says YHWH” (cf. [Exod. 7:16](#), [8:1](#)).

Purpose of Confrontation

Pharaoh refuses God's demands because he does not know who YHWH is. The purpose of the confrontation is to demonstrate to Egypt and the rest of the world who YHWH is.

Exodus 5:2 Instructor's Translation

But Pharaoh said, "**Who is YHWH** that I should listen to his voice by sending Israel away?
I do not know YHWH, and furthermore I will not send Israel away." "Let my people go!"

Let My People Go

There are two main ways the text expresses the demand for the release of the Israelites: שלח ("send away"; *piel*) and הלך ("let go"; *hiphil*).

You Will Know that I am YHWH

In six of the ten plagues, God makes his purpose clear—that "you will know that I am YHWH."

- Blood: "By this you will know that I am YHWH" ([Exod. 7:17](#))
- Frogs: "so that you may know there is no one like YHWH" ([Exod. 8:10](#))
- Flies: "so that you will know that I, YHWH, am in this land" ([Exod. 8:22](#))
- Hail: "so you may know that there is no one like me in all the earth" ([Exod. 9:14](#))
- Hail: "so you may know that the earth is YHWH's" ([Exod. 9:29](#))
- Locusts: "that you may know that I am YHWH" ([Exod. 10:1-2](#))
- Firstborn: "you will know that YHWH makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel" ([Exod. 11:7](#))

Reflection Question

What is the purpose of Moses' confrontation with Pharaoh?